Priority Whiplash

THE PRODUCT MANAGER FIELD GUIDE



Help with the urgent request without quietly asking the team to keep every old promise too.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

Reading times are approximate. Allow longer for notes and conversations.

WORKING EDITION / REBEL-LEADER.COM

“Can we squeeze this in for Friday?”

About 2 min read

You have just explained the week’s plan. Now Sales messages you about Friday’s customer meeting, and someone has already asked a developer for a quick demo. You need to help without making the team absorb another invisible commitment.

Check what has already started

Ask what Sales needs the customer to decide and whether anyone has begun work. A sketch, a clickable demonstration, and a live feature are different asks. Find out which one is needed before agreeing to “a quick demo.”

Check whether it fits

List the work already promised and ask the team what the new request would take. Include support, testing, and review. Sometimes it fits. If it doesn’t, something needs to change.

Make the cost visible

Show the useful result each option would give the customer and the existing work it would interrupt. Include the time to stop and pick that work up again. Bring a recommendation; a list of competing priorities leaves the difficult choice with the team.

Get a clear answer

If you’re allowed to make the call, make it and tell the people affected. If it changes commitments someone else owns, take the recommendation to them. Record what is decided.

Start by getting the current work and the new request in one place. That gives you something concrete to talk through with the team.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You don’t want to be the PM who always says no.

About 2 min read · allow 5-10 min for your notes

You also don’t want another Friday where the team stays late and the original customer still asks where their fix is. Prepare to explain the choice without treating the requester as the problem.

Catch the automatic yes

If you say “we’ll try” before checking, people may hear a commitment. Try: “Let me check what a demo would take and what it would move. I’ll come back this afternoon.” Give a time for your answer that you can keep.

Find out why this request matters

A sales opportunity can be real even if it arrived badly. Ask what the customer will decide on Friday and what happens if the team cannot provide a new demo. Do not assume enthusiasm means the full feature is needed.

Notice whose promise you are tempted to hide

It is easier to disappoint a customer who is not in this meeting. Bring their report fix, deadline, and account manager into the choice. Avoid treating quiet stakeholders as spare capacity.

Check the work, not people’s willingness

Someone may offer to do both to avoid the argument. Ask what they would stop, what review they need, and when they would actually do it. Optional private Lab notes are for your preparation; they disappear when you refresh or leave and are not exported.

Try: “I want Friday to be useful. Before I say yes, let’s look at what we’d be asking the team to put down.”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Find out what Friday is really for.

About 1 min read

“We need a demo” can mean several different things. A few questions now can spare people a week of work on the wrong answer.

Ask what they need to learn

What will the customer decide after seeing it? Are they choosing between ideas, checking a workflow, or expecting working software?

Ask what would be enough

Would sketches let them respond? Do they need to click through the screens? What would a working version tell them that a demonstration would not?

Check why now

What is fixed about Friday? Who confirmed it? If the timing is a preference, that may give us another option.

Say why you are asking

I want us to give the customer something useful on Friday. If I understand what they need, I can ask the team what it would take.

Let the answer change your understanding of the work before deciding whether it fits.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What are we already asking people to do?

About 2 min read

Use names people recognize. “Fix the broken invitation link” tells us more than “onboarding improvement.”

Start with the people waiting

A new customer can’t join their account. Another customer is waiting for corrected report figures. Describe the work and who needs it.

Include the interruption itself

Ask what someone would have to stop and what it would take to resume. The developer who can build the demo may also be the only person who can fix the report. Total hours across the team do not make those skills interchangeable.

Describe the new request

Who asked, what do they need, and by when? Find out what they will use it for. In our example, the customer needs to react to a proposed report screen on Friday.

Check the deadline

Ask what confirms the timing. A booked customer meeting is different from a preferred date. Record what you have checked and what you still need to ask.

Try: “What does the customer need to see on Friday? Would the sketches we already have be useful, or do they need to click through it?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What would have to wait?

About 2 min read

Let’s check with the people doing the work. If the request won’t fit, what could be smaller, happen later, or wait while this gets done?

Name the work that changes

In the example, a simple demonstration takes two days of team effort. That would mean putting off two days of work correcting a customer's report. Say who needs to know.

Use the time check if it helps

One person-day means one person working for one day. Two people each working for one day add up to two person-days. Compare available time and required work over the same dates. Include review and support.

Understand what the numbers can tell you

Ten days available, ten already needed, and two more requested means the entered plan needs twelve days of effort. The extra two must be addressed. It doesn’t tell you the new finish date; ask the team about skills, waiting, and the order of work.

Keep another option open

Perhaps the existing sketches would do. Perhaps the demonstration can wait. Protect essential checks and customer promises, and explain the consequences of each choice.

Changing the written recommendation doesn’t change the calculator. Its numbers describe the work you entered before the proposed change.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make the choice visible without making it a threat.

About 1 min read

You are helping people choose how to use the time available. The work already promised and the new opportunity both deserve a fair hearing.

1 / Check the whole week

Are support, review, meetings, and fixes included? Are these the right people and the same dates? Ask the team to correct the list.

2 / Name who would wait

Which customer or colleague would lose something if we changed the plan? What have we told them, and who can discuss a different date with them?

3 / Keep a smaller option

Could sketches answer Friday's question? Could part of the demonstration wait? Explain what each option would help the customer decide.

4 / Check the result together

Ten days available and twelve needed exposes a gap. It does not tell us which work to delay or what a new finish date should be.

Try: "Here are two ways we could help on Friday. Can we look at what each means for the people already waiting?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What do you think we should do?

About 2 min read

You have looked at what would change. Which option would you recommend, and why? That gives the person making the call a useful place to start.

Make the choice specific

“Prepare the small demonstration and postpone the report correction” is a choice. “Be more flexible” isn’t enough for anyone to act on.

Explain who benefits and who waits

The customer in Friday's meeting can react to the idea. The customer waiting for correct report figures waits longer. Both belong in the conversation.

Make the call at the right level

If you can reorder this work, decide after hearing the people affected. If it changes a customer commitment outside your authority, take the choice to the product director. Do not ask Engineering to settle a disagreement between business priorities.

Say when an answer is needed

In the example, Wednesday afternoon gives the team time to change the plan and tell the account manager by Thursday morning.

Try: “I recommend the small demonstration, with the report correction moved back. We need a decision by Wednesday so we can tell the people affected.”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Get the right people into the decision.

About 1 min read

A request from someone senior can still need a decision from the person who owns the commitments it would change.

Who brings the recommendation?

The PM gathers the team's estimates and the customer needs. Include what the requester has told you and what the affected customer is waiting for.

Who must be heard?

Ask the people building and checking the work, the requester, and the person responsible for the delayed customer promise. Record any unanswered questions.

Who can make the call?

Name the person allowed to reorder these commitments. Check their authority and the required approvals instead of assuming the loudest request decides it.

When do we need the answer?

Leave time to change the plan and tell people. If no answer comes, follow the existing agreed plan within your authority and ask when a decision can be made.

A recommendation can be accepted, changed, or declined. Record the answer people actually give.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Keep bringing it back to the actual work.

About 2 min read

People may see a consequence you have missed. Listen, check the facts, and adjust the recommendation where needed.

“They are all top priority”

“Which should the team work on first? If the new request goes first, are we agreeing that the report correction waits?”

“It is only a day or two”

“Who has those two days? The person who can do the demo is fixing the report. Can we use the sketches, or are we agreeing to make that customer wait?” Check the estimate with the team, including review and the cost of restarting work.

“Nothing can move”

“Then I can offer the sketches for Friday. I can’t also promise a new demo on the current plan.” If the person insists, take the unresolved choice to whoever can change the commitments. Make the conflict visible before it becomes overtime.

“This is an emergency”

Follow the incident process if it is a real emergency. Name who can authorize the interruption, which work pauses, and when the temporary arrangement will be reviewed.

Try: “I can see why Friday matters. Here is what we could do, and what would have to wait. Can we choose a plan together?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make sure “wait” really means wait.

About 1 min read

A written tradeoff achieves little if the team is still expected to do both pieces of work. Check what the decision means in practice.

For the person deciding

Explain what the demonstration helps the customer do, which work would wait, and the alternative. Ask for a response by the time the team needs it.

For the team

After agreement, name the work to start and the work to pause. Ask whether anyone has received conflicting instructions or is still being measured against the old plan.

For the customer who waits

Ask the account manager to explain the change and confirm the revised date after the team checks it. Don’t calculate that date by adding the effort gap to the calendar.

After Friday

Did the demonstration answer the customer’s question? Did the report correction actually wait? If people did both in overtime, bring that back into the next conversation.

Use the Lab’s final step to prepare the updates and record what happened when the plan met the real week.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A Friday demonstration meets a full week.

About 2 min read

Fictional example: the team is fixing a broken account invitation, checking customer-data security, and correcting inaccurate report totals. The sales director now wants a demonstration for Friday.

What is already promised

New customers need the invitation fix. The next software update needs security checks. An existing customer needs corrected report figures. Support and review are included in the team's estimate of ten days of work.

What the new request means

The customer wants to react to a proposed report screen. A simple clickable demonstration would take two more days. The team has ten days of work time between them before Friday, and all ten are already needed.

The recommendation

Make a simple clickable demonstration and put off two days of work on the incorrect report totals. Check the new report-fix date with the team before promising it.

The decision and follow-up

In this example, the product director agrees on Wednesday to postpone the report correction. The team checks its new finish date. The product manager updates the plan; the account manager tells the affected customer. They review what happened after Friday's meeting. The Lab example starts before the decision.

> If the new work had fitted, there would have been no need to invent a tradeoff. Here it doesn't fit, so the people involved make a clear choice.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

From a new request to a clear answer.

About 1 min read

Bring one new request and the work it competes with. You can prepare alone, then check your assumptions with the team.

Current work

List the current commitments, the new request, and why it matters now. Preview Current Work List if you want someone to check it.

What changes

Check the time available if useful. Write what would wait, who would be affected, and another option. Preview What Would Change to review the consequences.

Recommend

Write your recommendation, name the person who can decide, and say when you need an answer.

Record

Keep the status as PROPOSAL before the conversation and leave the actual decision blank. Preview Priority Decision Brief. After the conversation, record the response, update who will do what, and rebuild the brief.

Copy, download, or print the brief to take into your usual work tools. The Lab doesn’t send it or change the team's plan. Use Load Examples to see fictional answers for the current step. You’ll be asked before existing answers are replaced.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Did the work actually stop?

About 2 min read

You agreed to postpone the report fix. Then the account manager messages its developer to ask whether they could “just finish it anyway.” This is where a priority decision either holds or disappears.

Give the team one plan

Confirm what starts, what pauses, and what continues. Ask whether anyone has received a different instruction. If they have, resolve it with the requester and the person who made the call; do not leave the developer to choose whom to disappoint.

Tell the customer who is waiting

Check that the account manager explained the change and that any new date came from the team. Two person-days of displaced effort do not automatically mean a two-day calendar delay.

Check whether Friday was worth the interruption

What did the customer learn or decide from the demo? Did the report fix really pause, or did someone do both in the evening? Record both the useful result and the work it cost.

Address the repeat request

If this keeps happening, ask Sales to check the purpose and effort of a demo before promising it. If nobody can make competing priorities stick, use Mandate Reset for that decision problem. Export the brief if you need a shared record; Lab drafts stay in this browser.

A useful priority decision gives someone permission to leave work unfinished while they do the work you chose.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What did this week teach the team?

About 1 min read

Repeated urgent requests shape more than a work list. Notice the habits people learn from how each request is handled.

Identity

Can someone be dependable without saying yes to everything? What did this decision teach people about using their judgment?

Relationship

Did the requester and the team understand each other better? Were the people whose work moved treated with care?

Vision

Did a clear customer need help you choose, or did the most recent request simply win? What worthwhile result are you protecting?

Culture

Can people point to work that was genuinely paused? If everything stays urgent, what needs to change in how requests enter the team's week?

Notice the pattern across several weeks, not just one request. You can think about the effects on people without recording personal information.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

About 1 min read

1 / Another urgent request

The team is fixing broken account invitations, checking customer-data access, and correcting a report. Sales now asks for a demonstration on Friday. The PM first asks what the customer needs from the meeting.

PM

“What do they need to decide on Friday? Do they need the report to work, or to see how the screen might work?”

Sales director

“They want to see the idea and tell us what they think. It doesn’t have to work yet.”

Ask yourself: What does the request mean in actual work, now that you have asked?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

About 1 min read

2 / Look at the time

The fictional estimates are ten person-days available, ten already needed, and two for a clickable demonstration. The plan would need twelve. Those figures include support and review; they do not predict a finish date.

Engineering lead

“A clickable demo would take us about two days. We can fit it in if the report fix waits.”

PM

“Let’s also keep the existing sketches as an option. The report customer is waiting for accurate figures.”

Ask yourself: Do the figures cover the same people, dates, and necessary checks?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

About 1 min read

3 / Bring two choices

The PM recommends a small clickable demonstration only if the product director agrees to postpone the report correction. The alternative is to use the sketches and keep all current work. The decision is still open.

PM

“I’d do the clickable demo if we agree the report fix waits. Otherwise, we can use the sketches. Could you decide by Wednesday afternoon?”

Product director

“Can’t we do both? The report customer has already waited long enough.”

PM

“I checked with the lead. The same person is needed for both. We can use the sketches without moving the fix. If you want the clickable demo, we need to tell the other customer what changes.”

Ask yourself: Have you made the cost to the other customer as clear as the benefit to Friday’s customer?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

About 1 min read

4 / Record what was chosen

In this fictional continuation, the director approves the smaller demonstration and the delay. The team checks the report date. The PM updates the plan, and the account manager tells the affected customer.

Product director

“Let’s do the small demo and put the report fix on hold. Keep going with the invitation fix and security checks.”

PM

“I’ll get the report date checked and make sure the account manager can explain the change.”

Ask yourself: Who needs a different instruction now that the decision is made?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

About 1 min read

5 / See what actually happened

This example ends with a check, not a victory lap. The group asks whether the demonstration helped, the delayed customer was told, and the team actually stopped the postponed work.

PM

“Did Friday help? And did the report work actually wait?”

Engineering lead

“The customer showed us which figures they need. The account manager still asked for the fix on Thursday, though. I pointed them back to the agreed plan.”

PM

“Thanks. I’ll check the customer got the new date. Next time we need to explain the pause to the account manager before the team changes work.”

Ask yourself: What small change would make the next urgent request easier to handle?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

Your Company's God is Showing

Nic Payne · Article

Use Nic's essay to examine what repeated urgency says about what matters in the organization.

What does the team see us protect when we are under pressure?

Take this into your Lab >

[C]ulture → [V]ulture

Nic Payne · Article

Look at what living with the current pace does to a person over time.

Who keeps absorbing the work that never fits?

Take this into your Lab >

Leadership as bowl, water, and current

Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

Consider the space you make for the requester and the people already carrying the work.

Whose experience has not been heard in this decision?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

[You Have a Culture Problem]

Nic Payne · Article

Trace how repeated choices about urgent work become expectations and habits.

What are we teaching people to expect the next time someone asks?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[When Mattering Isn't Enough]

Nic Payne · Article

Nic asks what happens beyond feeling valued. Consider whether the way work is assigned gives people room to grow.

What cost to people is missing from our work list?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[Work in process limits]

DORA / Google Cloud · Research-informed practice guide

Use this guide to discuss how much work to start and how to include tasks that are easy to overlook.

What could we finish sooner if we stopped starting so many things?

[Take this into your Lab >]

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

Shape Up — Chapter 3: Set Boundaries

Ryan Singer · Book chapter

Explore a smaller useful answer within the time available.

What could Friday's customer learn from something smaller?

Take this into your Lab >

RAPID® Decision Making

Bain & Company · Originator's framework explanation

Check who advises on the choice and who can change the commitments involved.

Who can decide which customer promise waits?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic's teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 02

The new request is somebody's problem, too.

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

Ask what the customer meeting needs to accomplish. A request that sounds careless from your side may carry a commitment you have not heard about. Understanding that does not erase the team's existing work. It gives you something real to work out together.

Worth asking: What do they need to happen, and what have they not heard about your situation?

ChapGPT schools me on leading well
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 03

Include the work nobody put on the list.

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

DORA's guide to work in process limits includes support and maintenance alongside planned work. Use that reminder when listing commitments. Starting more work can leave everything waiting; a full calendar alone does not tell you what the team can finish.

Worth asking: What keeps interrupting the team but never appears in the plan?

Work in process limits
DORA / Google Cloud · Research-informed practice guide

CHAPTER 04

Who pays for the extra work?

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

"Does our pace grow or shrink people?"

Nic Payne · Your Company's God is Showing

Look at the cost to people as well as the work. If the demo only fits because someone gives up evenings, swallows a concern, or loses the time they needed to learn, put that into the discussion. Ask the people affected. The cost does not disappear because the plan leaves it out.

Worth asking: What would need to change for the team to do this without quietly paying for it themselves?

Your Company's God is Showing
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 05

The calculator cannot make the choice for you.

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

Ten days of work plus two more days will not fit into ten available days. That helps reveal the conflict. It cannot decide whose promise matters most, whether the work is ready to start, or what repeated interruptions do to trust and concentration. Bring those questions into the decision.

Worth asking: What matters here that the numbers do not show?

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part III - How We Trained Ourselves to Mistake Certainty for Wisdom
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 09

What are these repeated emergencies teaching people?

About 1 min read · linked reading varies

If the loudest request always wins, people may learn that careful planning and honest commitments count for little. Cultural Orbital Mechanics asks how that experience shapes relationships, identity, and the future people can imagine together. Try one agreed way to consider new work, then see what changes.

Worth asking: Can people now raise a conflict early and take part in deciding what happens?

You Have a Culture Problem
Nic Payne · Article

Why Work Can't Be Your Church
Nic Payne · Article

Kill the Ghost Goal
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

Explore more of Nic’s Holistic Shaping work at Rebel Leaders.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.